ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Evidentiality and modality

Two sentences may share a conclusion but not a source. Precise C2 English distinguishes what was observed, what was reported and what was inferred.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Communicate both the conclusion and the route through which the evidence was obtained.

Signal how you know something—observation, report or inference—and calibrate certainty with seem, appear, reportedly, be bound to and related forms.

MODEL

The device appears to have been damaged in transit.

evidential source + calibrated modality + proposition

6 GUIDED STAGES · 29 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Mark the source of a claim.

OUTCOME 2

02

Separate evidential source from degree of certainty.

OUTCOME 3

03

Select neutral, cautious or firm forms that match the writer's responsibility.

Build meaning before form

Signal how you know something—observation, report or inference—and calibrate certainty with seem, appear, reportedly, be bound to and related forms.

Source and certainty are separate dimensions

Reportedly marks indirect sourcing but does not guarantee reliability. Must have expresses a strong inference but does not name the source. A precise writer controls both dimensions independently.

Ask first where the information comes from; then ask how strongly that evidence supports the proposition.

Appearance, report and inference

Seem and appear point to indications; be said or reported attributes a claim; must and can’t have express logical inference. Apparently and evidently can shift meaning with context, so concrete evidence should accompany them.

The same event can therefore be framed differently without becoming synonymous.

Reading	Form
observable indication	appears to
external source	is reported to
logical conclusion	must have

Fine-grained commitment

Be bound to expresses a very strong expectation. May well presents a possibility the speaker considers reasonably supported. Would seem to combines inference with deliberate distance.

Select the form that corresponds to the risk of error and the communicative consequences of being wrong.

Responsible attribution

Evidential grammar helps readers distinguish knowledge from hearsay, prediction and interpretation. It should make accountability clearer, not blur it.

Whenever possible, pair indirect wording with a named report, observable sign or explicit reasoning chain.

02 · VISUAL MAP

Reason through the pattern

Three routes—observe, hear and infer—lead to different degrees of commitment. The learner labels both the source route and the certainty level.

01	02	03
evidential source	calibrated modality	proposition

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Never present a report or appearance as independently confirmed fact.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Source/stance	Markers	Example
appearance	seem/appear	It appears to be stable.
report	reportedly/is said to	It was reportedly delayed.
inference	must/can't have	They must have left.
strong expectation	be bound to	Costs are bound to rise.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

appears to	observable indication
is reportedly	external source
must have	strong inference
may well	reasonable possibility

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using reportedly as a shield without a traceable source.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Treating appears as direct proof.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Stacking markers whose meanings contradict one another.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

The surface ___ to have been exposed to heat.

OPTIONS appears · reports · is bound · must reportedly

A2 · CONTEXT 2

The minister is ___ considering an early election.

OPTIONS reportedly · visibly must · bound perhaps · appearing report

A3 · CONTEXT 3

The lock is intact; they ___ entered through the door.

OPTIONS can’t have · reportedly · seem report · are bound have

A4 · CONTEXT 4

With demand rising this fast, prices are ___ increase.

OPTIONS bound to · reported to maybe · appearing · must to

A5 · CONTEXT 5

The delay ___ affect the final phase.

OPTIONS may well · reports to · is appeared to · can’t well

A6 · CONTEXT 6

The available evidence ___ suggest a procedural error.

OPTIONS would seem to · is bound proving · reports surely · must reportedly to

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

The talks are _____ close to agreement, but the final text _____ to remain contested.

OPTIONS Gap 1: reportedly / appearingly / must report · Gap 2: appears / reports / is bound certainly

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

The seal _____ to have been broken before delivery; the damage _____ have occurred in transit.

OPTIONS Gap 1: seems / reports / is bound · Gap 2: may well / reportedly to / appears

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

The shortage is _____ to continue, and costs _____ rise further.

OPTIONS Gap 1: expected / appearing / must reportedly · Gap 2: are bound to / appear that / reportedly

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

The outage _____ to have begun shortly after the update. According to the operator, a configuration error is _____ responsible. However, the logs _____ suggest that two systems failed simultaneously. A second review _____ reveal additional causes, and the final report is _____ to be released next week.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

appeared · appearing · appears · are bound · can’t have · expected · is bound · is reported · may well · must have · must reportedly · reportedly · reportedly to · reports · would seem to

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

There are signs of damage: The unit _____ damaged. A source says she will resign: She _____ resign. The evidence rules out remote access: They _____ accessed it remotely. An increase is highly likely: It _____ rise. The possibility is reasonably supported: This _____ explain the discrepancy.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Write an original Evidentiality and modality response for context 1. Include reportedly negotiating, is reported to be negotiating.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Write an original Evidentiality and modality response for context 2. Include appears to have been modified.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Write an original Evidentiality and modality response for context 3. Include can’t have used, cannot have used.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Correct: The price is bound increasing.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Evidentiality and modality response for context 1. Include appears, reportedly, must.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Evidentiality and modality response for context 2. Include reported, would seem.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Evidentiality and modality response for context 3. Include reportedly, source.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: source.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: certainty.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: inference.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: attribution.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

appears

Use “appears”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

A2

reportedly

Use “reportedly”. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

A3

can’t have

Use “can’t have”. Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information.

A4

bound to

Use “bound to”. Never present a report or appearance as independently confirmed fact.

A5

may well

Use “may well”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

A6

would seem to

Use “would seem to”. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

reportedly / appears

Use “reportedly”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred. Use “appears”. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

B2

seems / may well

Use “seems”. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence. Use “may well”. Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information.

B3

expected / are bound to

Use “expected”. Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information. Use “are bound to”. Never present a report or appearance as independently confirmed fact.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

appears

Use “appears”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

C2

reportedly

Use “reportedly”. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

C3

would seem to

Use “would seem to”. Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information.

C4

may well

Use “may well”. Never present a report or appearance as independently confirmed fact.

C5

expected

Use “expected”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

appears to be

Use “appears to be”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

D2

is reportedly going to

Use “is reportedly going to”. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

D3

can’t have

Use “can’t have”. Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information.

D4

is bound to

Use “is bound to”. Never present a report or appearance as independently confirmed fact.

D5

may well

Use “may well”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The company is reportedly negotiating a sale.

Use “The company is reportedly negotiating a sale.”. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

E2

The file appears to have been modified.

Use “The file appears to have been modified.”. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

E3

They can’t have used the main entrance.

Use “They can’t have used the main entrance.”. Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information.

E4

The price is bound to increase.

Use “The price is bound to increase.”. Never present a report or appearance as independently confirmed fact.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The system appears to be stable. It is reportedly stable. Given the test results, it must be stable.

The model combines accurate Evidentiality and modality with a clear purpose. Decide whether the claim is observed, reported or inferred.

F2

The treatment is reported to help, but the limited sample would seem to rule out firm conclusions.

The model combines accurate Evidentiality and modality with a clear purpose. Assess the strength and limits of the evidence.

F3

Replace “The firm will close” with “The firm is reportedly considering closure,” and cite the source.

The model combines accurate Evidentiality and modality with a clear purpose. Use one source marker and one certainty marker only when both add information.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____